

# KATHA STUDIO

## A Wrestler's Promise

*A young wrestler is offered a shortcut of trophies. The mud remembers who he promised to remain, and pride arrives looking like a championship.*

Book 05 · Sports fable · Amritsar outskirts

Lead: Raja Pahalwan · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading



*Before medals, there is mud. Before fame, there is a guru's silence.*

The akhara wakes before the highway. Oil lamps, mustard oil, the slap of feet practising not to lie. Raja Pahalwan runs laps around a peepal that has watched better men become worse.

**NARRATOR**

“Kushti is not a sport you win. It is a habit you keep.”

**THUD**





*Guru-ji's hands are maps of every throw he ever taught.*

Raja wants both: the throw and the applause. He is twenty-two, which is an age that thinks it can negotiate with gravity and uncles simultaneously.

**GURU-JI**

“Strength is cheap. Who you refuse — that is expensive.”

**BREATH**



*Dawn chores: sweep the pit, milk the buffalo, do not skip either.*

Guru-ji does not answer with words. He hands Raja the broom as if it were a championship belt that had not yet learned vanity.

**RAJA**

“If I am famous, can someone else sweep?”

**SWISH**





*A promoter arrives with gold cups that clink like hollow teeth.*

The offer includes a poster in which Raja's neck is thicker than truth. Also a scooter. Also a cousin's wedding paid for. The mud listens.

**PROMOTER**

“Throw the next three bouts as I say. The city will chant by Friday.”

**CLINK**



*Raja looks at the cups, then at the man who taught him to stand.*

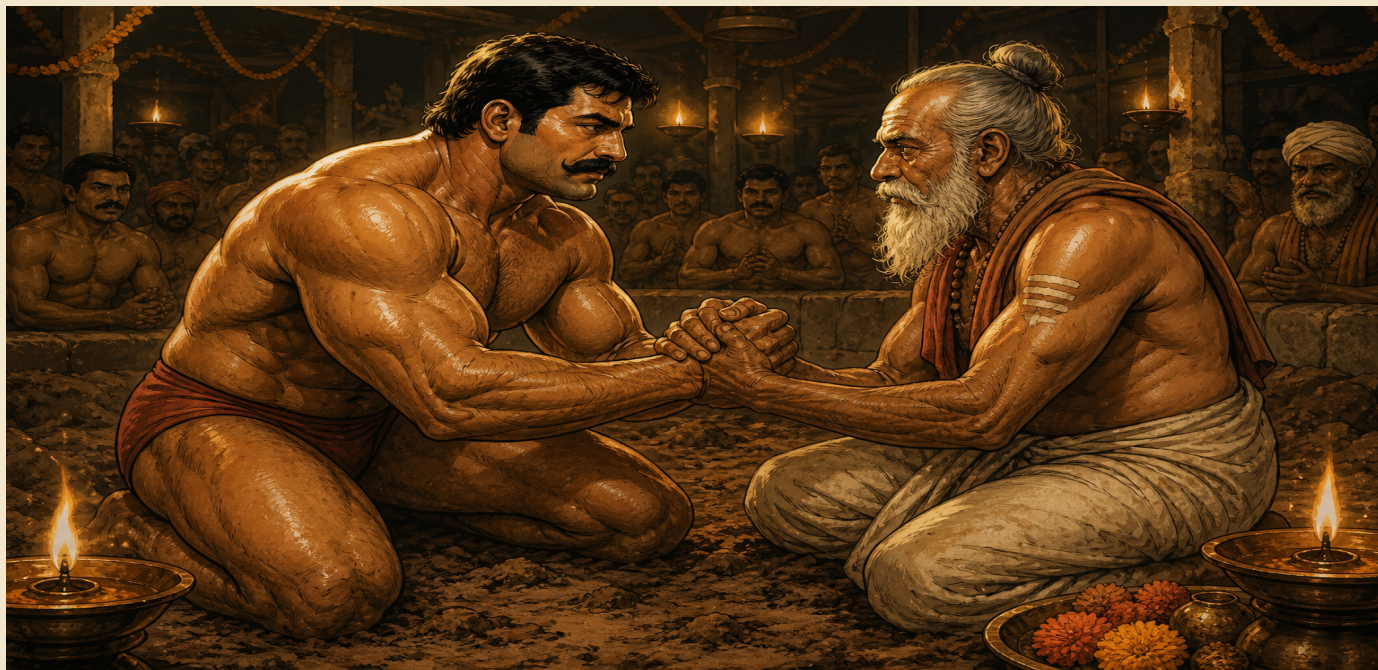
The promoter smiles like someone who has heard no from hungrier men. He leaves a visiting card that smells of hotel soap and other people's losses.

**RAJA**

“If the city chants a lie, it is not my name they are using.”

**NO**





*Practice that afternoon is uglier. Raja's mind is doing extra rounds.*

They wrestle until Raja's pride is as tired as his shoulders. Tired pride is easier to supervise.

**GURU-JI**

"Your opponent today is a sentence you almost said yes to."

**SLAP**



*Pride arrives anyway, as a smoke-and-medal giant in the pit.*

The villagers gather because smoke in an akhara is never just weather. Raja meets it the only way he trusts: forehead to chest, breath counted, no speech.

**PRIDE**

“Take the scooter. Take the chant. Take a rest from being good.”

**WHAM**





*The throw is not pretty. Pretty is for posters.*

Dust bursts. Children cheer the way children cheer thunder. The giant thins into ordinary evening, which is all pride ever was when asked to show identification.

**RAJA**

“You can have the noise. I am keeping the mud.”

**CRACK**



*After, Raja sweeps. Champions still sweep the pit.*

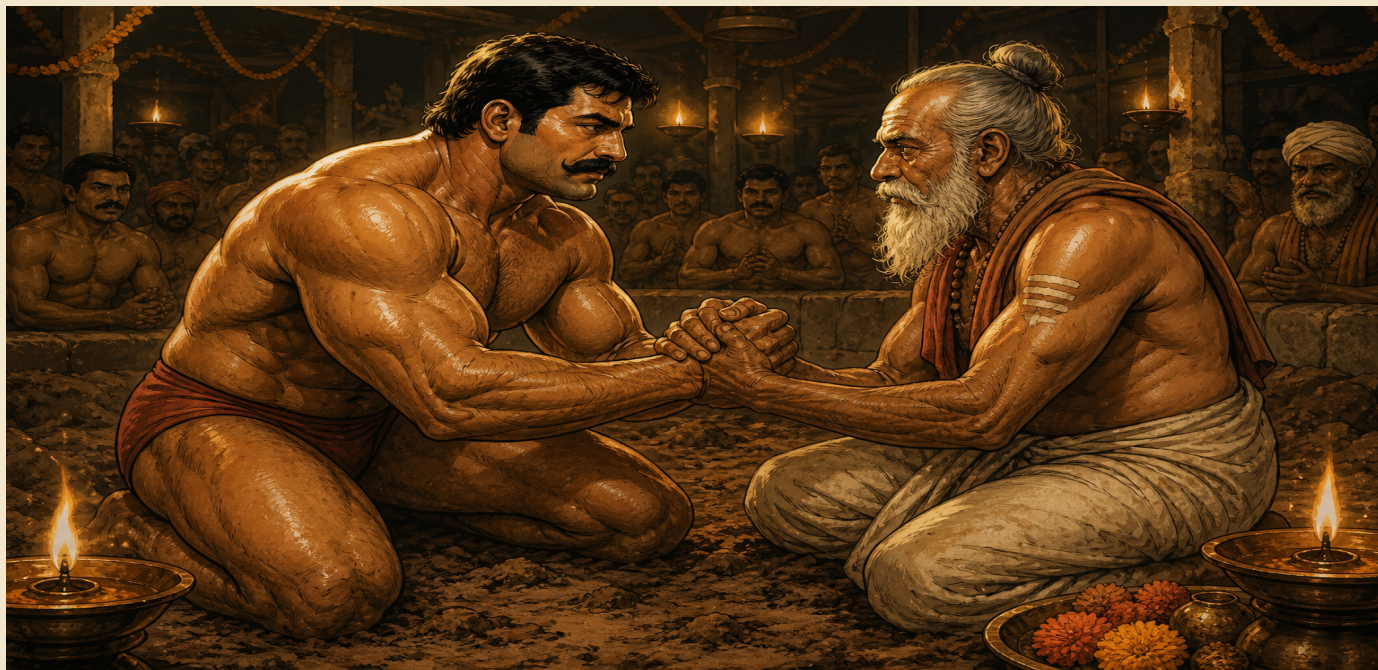
The cups remain unclaimed on a bench until a stray dog knocks one over. The sound is funny. Funny is allowed.

GURU-JI

“Good. Tomorrow we train at four.”

AMEN





*News travels to the city as a rumour that a boy refused money, which the city finds exotic.*

Raja says, Eat breakfast. The quote is printed anyway beside a photo that makes his biceps look like policy.

**REPORTER**

“Any message for the youth?”

**MIC**



*The promoter returns with a different mask: patriotism.*

Guru-ji spits, politely, into dust. Raja understands that flags are sometimes worn like rented jewellery.

**PROMOTER**

“Do it for the district. Do it for the flag. Do it so the other akhara looks small.”

**FLAG**





*A real bout: the other akhara's best, a man named Lakhbir who wrestles clean.*

They fight as if the pit were a sentence they both want to finish honestly. Raja loses the first fall and does not confuse that with dying.

**LAKHBIR**

“No promoters. Just mud.”

**GRIP**



*Second fall, Raja listens to Guru-ji's oldest advice: breathe where the other man forgets to.*

Lakhhbir laughs when he hits the ground, which is how you know the sport is still a sport. They share milk after. The promoter, watching from a car, looks allergic to milk.

**RAJA**

“Now.”

**THUD**





*Night. Raja oils Guru-ji's knees without being asked.*

Raja wants to say don't go. Instead he says four a.m. The peepal rustles like an official who approves.

**GURU-JI**

“When I am gone, refuse faster. I wasted years on almost.”

**OIL**



*A district official offers a stadium if Raja will wear a sponsor on his chest.*

Raja imagines children drinking a lie. He says the akhara is already a stadium if you count the sky. The official does not have a form for that.

**OFFICIAL**

“The children need a hero they can buy in a bottle.”

**POP**





*Winter. The pit hardens. So do excuses.*

He does not skip. A younger boy arrives, hungry in the eyes. Raja hands him the broom first, the way he was handed it, an inheritance of unglamorous light.

**RAJA**

“If I skip one morning, the mud will write my name wrong.”

**FROST**



*The younger boy is offered the same cups, smaller, shinier.*

Raja takes him to the dog that knocked the cup. They watch the dog be happy without a brand. It is a ridiculous lesson and it works because the boy likes dogs more than phones, still.

**BOY**

“Bhai, maybe just one thrown fight, for a phone?”

**PING**





*Festival bout. Marigolds. A crowd that wants a myth.*

Raja wins without dancing on anyone's name. He helps Lakhbir up before he lifts his own arms. The camera operators are confused and still film it.

**NARRATOR**

“Myths are heavy. Better to give them a clean throw instead.”

**ROAR**



*Guru-ji sleeps through the cheering, which is a kind of review.*

Raja covers him with a khes. The lamps go out one by one like obedient wrestlers.

**RAJA**

“We did not become a poster today.”

**SNORE**





*Years are not in this book, but mornings are.*

It was to the pit, to the man with map-hands, to the boy with the broom, to the version of himself that almost said yes and was allowed to be wrong only once.

**RAJA**

“The promise was never to the crowd.”

**BREATH**



*The visiting card is used to scrape mud off a toe.*

They laugh, which is also training.

GURU-JI

“Finally a use.”

**SCRAPE**





*Oil lamps. A bow. Dust that was never a demon for long.*

The highway grows louder. The peepal does not care. And in an akhara on the outskirts of Amritsar, a man who could have been a slogan chooses, again, to be a wrestler.

**NARRATOR**

“Raja Pahalwan, keeper of unfashionable strength.”

**FADE**